

Photo: HDX Team

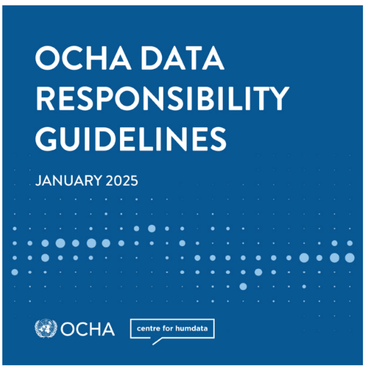
Data Responsibility

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Data responsibility in humanitarian action is the safe, ethical and effective management of personal and non-personal data for operational response. It is a critical issue for the sector to address and the stakes are high: the disclosure of sensitive data can lead to already vulnerable people and communities being further harmed or exploited. In addition to avoiding harm, responsible data management can lead to increased trust among humanitarian actors and with the people they seek to serve.

OCHA's role as data aggregator offers us a unique perspective into the multiple dataflows that exist within a crisis response and the many ways data is managed. The Centre's data responsibility work focuses on supporting adoption of data responsibility in OCHA and the wider sector. It also aims to help humanitarians navigate the technical and ethical issues involved when working with data in complex environments.

The Centre has led the development of the IASC Operational Guidance on Data Responsibility (first endorsed in February 2021 and revised in April 2023) and the OCHA Data Responsibility Guidelines (agreed in October 2021 and updated in January 2025). We have created a slide deck with an overview of the Guidelines and what is included in the January 2025 revision.



Supporting Adoption

Since the IASC Operational Guidance was first endorsed in 2021, humanitarians in 21 countries with a Humanitarian Response Plan (HRP) have adopted one or more actions for data responsibility. The most frequently adopted action is an Information Sharing Protocol (ISP), which serves as the primary reference document governing data and information sharing in a response.

Status of Information Sharing Protocols



Collective Action and Partnerships

Recognizing the need for common approaches, the Centre facilitates collective action on the evolution and implementation of system-wide frameworks for data responsibility. This work builds on the collaborative efforts spearheaded by the Centre around the development of the IASC guidance through the global Data Responsibility Working Group (DRWG), which the Centre co-chairs with the Danish Refugee Council, the International Organization for Migration (IOM) and the UN High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR).

Resources

- UN Secretariat Data Protection and Privacy Policy
- Guidance Note on Responsible Data Sharing with Donors
- Guidance Note on Data Responsibility and Accountability to Affected People in Humanitarian Action
- Guidance Note on Data Responsibility in Cash and Voucher Assistance
- UN Personal Data Protection and Privacy Principles
- ICRC Handbook on Data Protection in Humanitarian Action, 3rd edition

Related Links











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